A rich broth sets off the sweetness of the scallops while the chorizo adds a spicy contrast. Try serving as the first course of a dinner party menu.

creamy scallop bisque

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

3 cups water
1¼ cups dry white wine
1 tbsp butter
1 small onion, finely chopped
1 small shallot, very finely chopped
1 medium-sized ripe tomato, chopped
7oz (200g) shrimp, shelled
3½oz (100g) cod or pollock, skinned and cut into chunks
2 tbsp chopped parsley
2 tsp dill seeds
3 tbsp brandy
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
½ cup half-and-half
2½oz (75g) chorizo, diced
12 small scallops (or 6 large)
1 tbsp finely chopped chives, to finish

1 Boil the 3 cups water with the wine. Place the butter in a sauté pan over medium heat. Add the onion and shallot and soften until golden. Add the tomato, shrimp, fish, parsley, and dill seeds. Stir, and cook for 5 minutes. Stir in the brandy, and cook for a minute. Pour in the wine mixture and season lightly with salt and pepper. Reduce the heat, and simmer gently for 10 minutes. Take off the heat and let cool. Stir and mash down the soup with the back of a spoon, then heat the half-and-half in another pan until hot.

2 Transfer the soup to a blender and purée. Strain through a sieve back into the pan and stir in the hot half-and-half. Return to a simmer. Remove from the heat and adjust the seasoning. Cover and keep warm.

3 Place a nonstick frying pan over medium heat. Add the chorizo and cook for 3–5 minutes until cooked through and crispy. Set aside on a plate lined with paper towels and keep warm.

4 Add the scallops to the pan. Cook for 2 minutes, turn over, and cook for a minute. Remove from the heat. Ladle the soup into 4 bowls and add the scallops. Scatter the chorizo over the top and serve immediately.